Questions to Ask About Dad's Policies, Savings and Benefits, Sorted by Who Can Answer

Fifteen questions, grouped by the person each one belongs to, with room to write what they say.

Dad has a policy he bought years ago and a pension that arrives every month. You have questions about both, and it isn't obvious whether they go to the company, an attorney or someone else. This page sorts them. Bring the questions written down, ask them as they are, and write the answer under each one.

This guide doesn't answer the questions and doesn't say which matters most. The answers depend on Dad's own policies and accounts and on the rules in your state, and the people below are the ones who can give them.

Dad

These are his policies, his accounts and his decisions. Ask when it suits him, and write down what he says in his own words.

1. Which policies and accounts do you have, as far as you remember: long-term care insurance, life insurance, an annuity, retirement accounts? Where is the paperwork for each?

2. Have you ever looked into veterans benefits or any other benefits, and is there any paperwork from that?

The company behind each policy, or a licensed insurance professional

For what a policy or a plan says. Have the paperwork in front of you, and make the call together with Dad.

1. Here is Dad's long-term care insurance policy. What does it say it would do if he needed care, and what would he need to do to use it?

2. Here are his life insurance policy and his annuity contract. What does each one say as it stands today, and which papers should we keep with it?

3. What does Dad's health coverage say about long-term care?

A licensed financial professional

For questions about retirement accounts and other financial tools.

1. How might Dad's existing retirement accounts fit into paying for care later, and what would you want to see before you could say?

Your Medicaid planner

The person who looks at which financial issues could matter later for Medicaid purposes, and helps your family see which question belongs to which professional.

1. How much of Dad's money actually has to be spent?
2. Which of Dad's assets may be treated differently for Medicaid purposes, and is there anything on our list that may create a planning issue later?
3. Which financial strategies may be worth having a professional evaluate for our family, and which professional would that be?
4. What would you want us to have written down before anyone estimates what care could cost or how long Dad's resources might last?
5. If Dad is married: what should we write down about his spouse's financial needs and about housing?
6. Which changes in health, finances, marital status or care needs should prompt us to look at this again?

An elder law attorney

For legal advice, and for the legal side of any gift, transfer or change of ownership.

1. Are there legal ways to protect or reposition assets?
2. Before anyone makes a gift or a transfer, what are the possible consequences we should understand?

3. How would any financial step need to fit with Dad's legal planning?

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't answer these questions or put them in order of importance, and it doesn't suggest buying, changing or cancelling anything, or making any gift or transfer. Those appear here only as things to ask about. Nothing here is legal, financial, tax or insurance advice.

Ready for the next step?

Your questions are sorted, each with a person beside it. The planning interview asks about your family's situation as a whole and gives you a free planning report, so you can bring the same page to your Medicaid planner, to a licensed professional, or to any conversation about paying for care.

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